



**Your pregnancy is bound to trigger** lots of memories for your mother of her own pregnancies, so expect to hear many stories of when you were a baby.

## **TAKING THE STRAIN**

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There are a number of changes in your body during pregnancy that impact how you can exercise and how your body moves:

- The increased weight of the baby, placenta, enlarged uterus, extra blood, and breast tissue can put stress on your body, especially your muscles and skeleton.
- Postural changes due to changes in the center of gravity can increase your chances of developing hip, back, and knee problems.
- Relaxin (see [Stretching safely](#)), a pregnancy-related hormone that affects the ligaments, can increase flexibility and result in improper alignment of the spine and pelvis.

Effective and safe exercises are the most efficient way of maintaining and improving your posture and minimizing the stress on your body. Regular exercise (especially weight bearing such as walking and using weights) generally improves the bone density of your skeleton and your muscle strength.